

technical information with an enthusiastic and optimistic style, he used his mathematical prowess to consider how to improve on the technology. He was, after all, a Bronze medal winner at the International Olympiad in Informatics⁴ at the age of 18 and could reportedly add three-digit numbers in his head at twice the speed of the average human being.⁵

To that end, Buterin tinkered with a number of Bitcoin projects that would inform his future work on Ethereum. In a blog post titled “Ethereum: Now Going Public,” he started with a tip of the hat to Bitcoin:

I first wrote the initial draft of the Ethereum whitepaper on a cold day in San Francisco in November, as a culmination of months of thought and often frustrating work into an area that we have come to call “cryptocurrency 2.0”—in short, using the Bitcoin blockchain for more than just money. In the months leading up to the development of Ethereum, I had the privilege to work closely with several projects attempting to implement colored coins, smart property, and various types of decentralized exchange.⁶

The projects Buterin references in the last sentence approached the transaction of bitcoin using Bitcoin’s blockchain more abstractly. As we have already learned, transacting bitcoin involves the transmission of information that results in a debit or credit of a balance of bitcoin in a user’s address.

In his blog post, Buterin mentions *colored coins*. These involve the marking of an address in Bitcoin with information beyond just the balance of bitcoin in that address. Further identifiers could also be appended to the address, such as information that represented ownership of a house. In